UTTAR PRADESH

ARE MUSLIMS ANGRY WITH AKHILESH?

By Ashish Misra



MOHD ZAKIR/GETTY IMAGES

WIDENING GULF
File photo of SP chief Akhilesh Yadav with Azam Khan (left)

"Netaji did nothing." Renegade Samajwadi Party (SP) leader Shivpal Yadav wasn't mincing his words. He had just come out of Sitapur Jail after paying a visit to senior SP leader Azam Khan, lodged there for the past 26 months on charges of having grabbed land for his dream project, Rampur's Jauhar University. It's the first time he has spoken directly against elder brother Mulayam, who is still the much-revered 'Netaji' (leader) to everyone, even if the real target was his nephew and SP chief Akhilesh Yadav. With Azam Khan in the mix, what Uttar Pradesh is seeing is a scaling up of the not-so-latent hostilities that have dogged the Samajwadi Party for years, within its first family and beyond.

Shivpal has been playing a sullen fifth columnist ever since he formed the rebel Pragatisheel Samajwadi Party-Lohia (PSPL) in 2018. The last-minute entente with Akhilesh before the UP assembly poll was evidently not built on mortar strong enough to withstand SP's defeat. And so, the rebel is back taking potshots at his family. "If Mulayam and Akhilesh Yadav had wanted, Azam Khan would have been out of jail. If the party had staged a sit-in in Parliament, PM Narendra Modi would have been forced to intervene," he has said.

That Shivpal is taking Azam Khan's side is significant. In 2016, when the infighting within the SP became public, with then CM Akhilesh sacking his uncle from the cabinet, it was Azam who tried to mediate between the two. Five years later, as if following Shivpal's cue, leaders close to Azam have opened a front against the SP leadership. On April 10, Azam's media in-charge Shanu Khan said at a public programme: "We have a complaint with our party's national president. Azam Khan has been in jail for over two years, but Akhilesh is silent. He is not ready to speak up for Muslims. Till when will Muslims keep silent?" He called it "my personal opinion and the view of many workers". But one clue about where Azam stands came on April 24, when he refused to meet Ravidas Mehrotra, SP MLA from Lucknow Central, who had come visiting to Sitapur Jail.

A month and a half after the assembly poll results, the SP is finding itself unravelling a bit. Rumblings of displeasure against Akhilesh's leadership has led to about a dozen leaders being expelled—including former Agra MLA Jitendra Verma and former Ghazipur MP Radhe Mohan Singh. Prof Padma Tripathi of K.K. PG College, Etawah, says: "It may impact the SP's Yadav-Muslim alliance. The elections to 36 Legislative Council seats, results for which were announced on April 12, gave the first warning. The numbers are small but significant. Take the Bareilly-Rampur MLC seat. Of its total 4,880 voters, 1,796 are Muslim and 311 Yadav. SP candidate Mashkoor Ahmed Munna got only 401 votes, while BJP candidate Kunwar Maharaj Singh got 4,227 votes—clearly, a large number of Muslim voters had voted BJP. Despite the party's pro forma denial of any Muslim desertion, the fact is that all of SP's 21 Yadav candidates lost. With the general election just two summers away, Akhilesh is staring at a real challenge. ■

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